Read the article about the shortage of helium gas. Answer the following questions.

1. What do the following words found in the article mean?

   scarce .....

   finite .....

   frittered .....

   inert .....

2. Hydrogen is more buoyant than helium. Why is helium used in balloons rather than hydrogen?

   .....

   .....

3. Helium is the second most abundant element in the Universe. Why is there a shortage on Earth?

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4. Helium is needed to supercool the magnets in MRI scanners. Without helium they will not work. What are MRI scanners used for?

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5. Do you agree with the suggestion that helium filled party balloons should cost £75? Explain your answer.

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Teaching notes

The questions are designed to promote discussion between students about the issues surrounding the uses of helium and it's shortage. It could be used as a mini debate e.g. 'This house would ban helium filled party balloons'.

There is a matching interactive game to go with the article that gets students thinking about the diverse uses of elemental gases.

Below is a link to a short video that illustrates the uses of gases.

http://www.bbc.co.uk/learningzone/clips/gases-and-their-uses-no-narration/1610.html